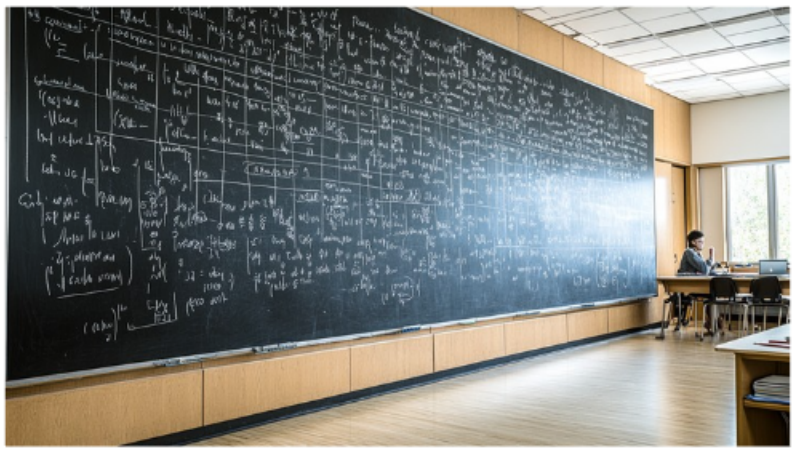
Why Didn’t Maya Learn?

Understanding student learning through one student’s journey

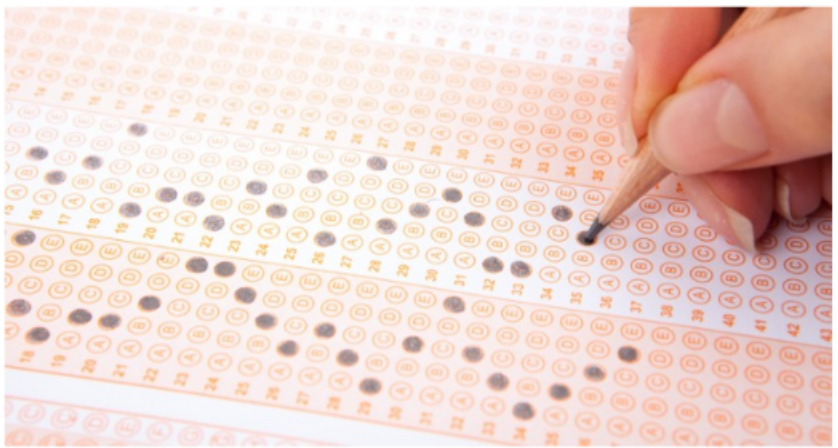
Presenter - Mohammed Yusuf Mujawar
Course - AHE 603



Maya's background







Maya's background

Maya scored 88%.

Two weeks later, she could not use the same concept in a new situation.

Did Maya learn?

QUICK VOTE

1. Yes - the score proves it.
2. Partly - she remembered but could not transfer.
3. No - application is required.
4. Not enough information yet.

Table of Content

01

What counts as learning?

Four lenses

02

Where can learning break down?

Three high-impact barriers

03

What can a teacher do?

Three aligned teaching moves

Learning objective **By the end, we will be able to diagnose one common barrier to student learning and select one teaching move that could address it.**

Four lenses on learning

Different theories emphasize different evidence of learning.

Behaviorism

Learning = observable change

Teacher move: Practice + reinforcement

Cognitivism

Learning = processing + memory

Teacher move: Connect + scaffold

Constructivism

Learning = meaning-making

Teacher move: Experience + reflection

Humanism

Learning = growth + meaning

Teacher move: Relevance + agency

Where can learning break down?

1

WHAT SHE BRINGS

Prior knowledge

New learning must connect to what Maya already knows - and incorrect prior knowledge can interfere.

2

WHAT SHE CAN PROCESS

Cognitive load

Too much unfamiliar information at once can exceed Maya's short-term processing capacity.

3

WHAT SHE CAN USE

Transfer

Knowing something in one setting does not guarantee that Maya can recognize and apply it elsewhere.

Diagnosing Maya

Using the frameworks

CASE

Maya practices ten problems that look almost identical to the professor's examples. On the exam, she solves similar problems correctly.

Two weeks later, the same underlying principle appears in a completely different context. She does not recognize that it applies.

What is the most visible learning challenge?

1 Prior knowledge

2 Cognitive load

3 Transfer

4 Attention

Teach Maya Differently

Match the teaching move to the learning barrier.

ACTIVATE

Before learning

Barrier Prior knowledge

Move Quick Write / Background Knowledge Probe

"What do you already know about ___?"

CHUNK

During learning

Barrier Cognitive load

Move Reduce + organize

Fewer ideas, clearer structure, retrieval pauses

TRANSFER

After learning

Barrier Transfer

Move Practice across contexts

Change the case, not the underlying principle

For transfer, the Cross Academy recommends being explicit, focusing on core concepts, and giving practice across different cases.

Returning to Maya

What changed in your answer?



88% on the test

Could not use it later

Did Maya learn?

Learning is more than having information.

It is developing or changing knowledge, skills, attitudes, values, or behavior - and being able to use what changes.

ACTIVATE → CHUNK → TRANSFER

"One change I could make in my own teaching to support learning is…"

References

- Barkley, E. F., & Major, C. H. (2026). Engaged Teaching: A Handbook for College Faculty (2nd ed.), Chapter 3: Understanding Student Learning.
- The K. Patricia Cross Academy.

Thank You!!!